

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Dr T Baksh

Address: 37 Sandy Lane Cheam SM2 7PQ

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer made comments in support of the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: I would like to record my support for application DM2025/01591. The proposal to convert the former 24 hour ambulance station into a community hub and place of worship is exactly the kind of development this area needs.

While the faith provision addresses a specific need in the Muslim community, the community hub is for all people of different backgrounds and a range of activities proposed, from education to wellbeing to social events, means this facility will benefit the whole neighbourhood.

Community hubs like the one proposed here are exactly the kind of preventative infrastructure that the NHS social prescribing model relies on. Providing a local space for wellbeing sessions, drop-ins, and community activities reduces pressure on GP surgeries and mental health services.

Moreover, the scale of the proposed works is restrained. The extension does not dominate the site or the street scene, and the height increase is limited to improving the internal functionality of the building. The external greening will soften the appearance of the site.

It is worth remembering what this site was before. An ambulance station operated here around the clock, with emergency vehicles coming and going at all hours, sirens, reversing beepers, engine noise, and crew changeovers through the night. A community facility with defined operating hours is a significant step down in terms of noise and disruption for neighbours.

I'd also add that some objectors have raised concerns about noise from prayers and events. The acoustic evidence shows these concerns are not well-founded. Even at the worst case, noise at

neighbouring properties stays below background levels. The building is well-insulated and the hours are restricted.

It is also worth mentioning that sutton's own Local Plan identifies community centres and places of worship as essential social infrastructure under Policy 33. This proposal is exactly what those policies were written to support. The NPPF requires authorities to plan positively for these uses.

Additionally, the former ambulance station operated 24 hours a day. The proposed facility has restricted hours. This is a straightforward improvement in terms of the impact on neighbours during unsociable hours.

In addition, the Belmont area lacks the kind of community infrastructure that other parts of the borough take for granted. This proposal would provide educational programmes, wellbeing sessions, social drop-ins, and faith provision, all within walking distance for local residents.

Furthermore, half of all attendees at Friday prayers walk, and fewer than 12% drive alone. The modal split for this facility is overwhelmingly sustainable. The proposed cycle storage will encourage even more sustainable travel. This is far better than many other developments the Council approves.

I'd also add that many women in faith communities are unable to access existing facilities because they are too far away, not accessible by public transport, or do not provide appropriate spaces. This proposal solves all three of those problems.

It is also worth mentioning that the planning system requires decisions to be made on material grounds. This application is policy-compliant, supported by thorough evidence, and addresses a clear community need. That should be what determines the outcome.

I support the grant of planning permission for DM2025/01591. This is the right use for this site, at the right time, and it deserves a positive outcome.